

Introduction to Theoretical Linguistics

Phonetics, Phonology and Morphology

Assignment 5

Name _____ ID _____

Ex 1 Phonological processes

Choose the best answer (A, B, C, or D) for each question.

- (1) In casual speech, the word *input* is often pronounced as [ɪmpʊt] instead of [ɪnpʊt]. Which phonological process does this represent?
 - A) Assimilation
 - B) Dissimilation
 - C) Metathesis
 - D) Deletion

- (2) When pronouncing the word *history*, people could say [hɪstri] instead of [hɪstəri]. What is this process called?
 - A) Insertion
 - B) Elision
 - C) Metathesis
 - D) Assimilation

- (3) Historically, the Old English word *brid* changed into the Modern English word *bird*. What is this phonological process called?
 - A) Assimilation
 - B) Dissimilation
 - C) Metathesis
 - D) Insertion

- (4) Some English speakers pronounce the word *February* / febrʊəri / as [[fɛbjuəri]]. This is an example of:
 - A) Assimilation
 - B) Dissimilation
 - C) Metathesis
 - D) Insertion

- (5) The English word *purple* comes from the Latin word *purpura* ‘purple’ with a phonological change. What process is this?
- A) Assimilation
 - B) Dissimilation
 - C) Metathesis
 - D) Deletion
- (6) When pronouncing the word *warmth*, many native speakers naturally insert a slight [p] sound between [m] and [θ], making it sound like *warm^pth* [wɔ:ɾmpθ]. What is the specific linguistic term for this type of phonological process?
- A) Epenthesis
 - B) Elision
 - C) Metathesis
 - D) Dissimilation
- (7) In rapid speech, the word *standby* [stændbaɪ] can be pronounced as [stæmbaɪ]. Which two phonological processes occur here?
- A) The /d/ is deleted, and the /n/ assimilates to the bilabial /b/.
 - B) The /d/ is deleted, and the /n/ dissimilates to the /n/.
 - C) The /n/ and /d/ undergo metathesis.
 - D) The /n/ is deleted, and the /d/ assimilates to the /æ/.

Ex 2 Historical change in English

Examine the following pairs of words. Column 1 shows the Old English (OE) forms, and Column 2 shows their corresponding Modern English (ModE) forms.

	Old English (OE)	Modern English (ModE)	Part of Speech	Notes
1	hros	horse	Noun	Common Germanic word for the animal.
2	brun	burn	Noun	Dialectal/archaic word meaning ‘brook’ or ‘small stream.’
3	brestan	burst	Verb	Strong verb meaning ‘to break open’ or ‘to shatter.’
4	cræt	cart	Noun	Referred to a two-wheeled vehicle or chariot.

	OE	ModE	PoS	Notes
5	fersc	fresh	Adjective	Originally meant ‘fresh, unsalted’ (as in fresh water).
6	forst	frost	Noun	Freezing weather or frozen dew.
7	beorht	bright	Adjective	Meant ‘shining,’ or ‘clear-sounding.’ It was estimated to be pronounced /beorxt/.
8	wyrhta	wright	Noun	Means ‘worker’ or ‘maker’ (as in <i>playwright</i> , <i>wheelwright</i>).

Q1. Identifying the Phenomenon

What is the specific linguistic term for the change between Old English and Modern English?

Q2: Applying the Rule

Based on your rule, how would you expect the Old English word *frist* (meaning ‘period of time’) to be spelled/pronounced in Modern English?

Q3. Tracing “Linguistic Fossils”

The older, pre-changed forms of words sometimes survive as “linguistic fossils” in historical place-names. For example, in Cumbria, England, there is a famous historical valley and lake called **Thirlmere**. The first part of this name, *Thirl-*, comes from the Old English word *pyrel*, which meant “a hole or opening pierced through something” (n.b., this same old root is hidden inside the modern word *nos-tril* [nose-hole]). Later in history, this exact same root underwent the relevant sound change, and it evolved into a very common Modern English verb. Can you guess what the modern word is?

Q4. Comparative Linguistics: English vs. German

Old English and Old German branched off from the same ancestor. In the following pairs, Modern German did not undergo the change in question, preserving the original position of the [r] sound from ancestral Germanic. With this in mind, deduce the **Modern English equivalents** for the following German words (*Hint: German "d" often corresponds to English "th"*).

1. German: **dritt-** → Modern English: _____
2. German: **dreizehn** → Modern English: _____
3. German: **durch** → Modern English: _____